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Trump Administration Actions: Geographic Naming

The naming or renaming of geographic features (e.g., mountains, lakes, streams) for federal usage is the responsibility of the [U.S. Board on Geographic Names](#) (BGN). However, in certain instances, the President or Congress has [directed](#) the name change of certain geographic features for federal use. Since January 2025, President Trump has issued several executive orders (EOs) directing the names of certain geographic features be changed. This includes changing the names of the Gulf of Mexico to the Gulf of America and Lake Ontario to Lake America, and reinstating the name of Mount McKinley in Alaska from Denali. In addition, the President provided broader directives for future policy regarding the federal process for establishing geographic names.

U.S. Board on Geographic Names

In 1947, P.L. 80-242 ([43 U.S.C. §§364-364f](#)) formally authorized the BGN, jointly with the Secretary of the Interior (Secretary), to provide for uniformity in geographic nomenclature throughout the federal government. The BGN is tasked with resolving name discrepancies; approving new names; validating and recording existing names; and promulgating all [official geographic feature names](#). The BGN is composed of representatives from various federal agencies and performs its duties through committees, such as the Domestic Names Committee (DNC) and the Foreign Names Committee (FNC). **Table 1** describes the DNC and FNC committee structures and duties. The committees meet to decide on geographic name issues pursuant to their principles, policies, and procedures.

BGN Principles, Policies, and Procedures

With some exceptions, the BGN considers name proposals on a case-by-case basis. Any individual or agency may submit a proposal to the BGN to change an existing name or to establish a new name for unnamed features; however, FNC policy states that it does not encourage proposals for foreign geographic names. When the FNC does receive foreign name proposals, "[FNC staff and the Committee address them, as appropriate.](#)" For domestic names, DNC [policy](#) recognizes two classes of name changes: (1) those made to bring official federal usage into agreement with established local usage and (2) those made to eliminate potential name issues (e.g., names asserted to be offensive or duplicate names).

With regard to commemorative naming proposals, DNC [policy](#) generally limits such naming to individuals who have been deceased at least five years and requires the individual to have some direct or long-term association with the feature or to have made a significant contribution to the area. For features that cross the Canadian border—which also fall within the purview of the DNC—[policies](#) direct the BGN to coordinate such proposals with the appropriate

foreign names authority pursuant to [an agreement signed in 1989](#). No equivalent agreement with Mexico has been signed; however, DNC [procedures](#) specify that the BGN should coordinate proposals for features crossing the Mexican border with the relevant naming authority (i.e., [Instituto Nacional de Estadística y Geografía](#)).

Table 1. Selected BGN Committees

Feature	DNC	FNC
Geographic Domain	Geographic names in the 50 states and in other areas under U.S. sovereignty, including U.S. territorial waters	Foreign geographic names for federal use, including oceans and seas but excluding Antarctica
Members	Departments of the Interior, Commerce, Agriculture, Defense, and Homeland Security; U.S. Postal Service; Government Publishing Office; Library of Congress	Departments of Commerce, Defense, Homeland Security, and State; Central Intelligence Agency; Library of Congress
Official Database	Geographic Names Information System	Geographic Names Server
Agency for Staff Support	U.S. Geological Survey	National Geospatial-Intelligence Agency

Sources: DNC, [Principles, Policies, and Procedures](#), December 2016; and FNC, [Principles, Policies, and Procedures](#), March 2026.

Notes: DNC = Domestic Names Committee; FNC = Foreign Names Committee. Does not include BGN committees on [Antarctic Names](#) and [Undersea Features](#).

In general, the BGN's policies that guide its consideration of geographic naming do not apply to names established by Congress, by treaty, or pursuant to an EO. In such instances, the BGN's role is to promulgate such names for official use, including updating the feature names in the relevant federal databases. In addition, DNC policy states that no decision will be made on any proposal that is also currently being considered by Congress.

Recent Executive Orders

Gulf of America and Mount McKinley. On January 20, 2025, President Trump signed [EO 14172](#), "[Restoring Names That Honor American Greatness](#)," to change the name of the Gulf of Mexico to the Gulf of America and reinstate the name of Mount McKinley in Alaska from Denali. Specifically, the EO directed the Secretary to take all appropriate actions within 30 days to rename the features, update the [Geographic Names Information System](#)

(GNIS) to reflect these renamings, and remove all references to the previous names, consistent with applicable law. The EO also directed the BGN to provide guidance to ensure all federal references, including on agency maps, contracts, and other documents and communications, reflect the Gulf of America renaming. More generally, the EO directed the BGN to advance a policy to honor “the contributions of visionary and patriotic Americans in our Nation’s rich past” by “the naming of our national treasures.” Section 5 stated that the Secretary may solicit input regarding additional commemorative naming and is to recommend action to the Assistant to the President for Domestic Policy. Section 2 further specified that the BGN “may update its principles, policies, and procedures as needed to achieve this policy.”

On February 7, 2025, the Secretary issued [Secretarial Order \(SO\) 3423](#) directing the BGN to rename the Gulf of Mexico to the Gulf of America and update the GNIS. The [GNIS](#) and the [Geographic Names Server](#) (GNS) now list the name as the Gulf of America. On February 14, 2025, the Secretary issued [SO 3424](#) directing the BGN to reinstate the name Mount McKinley, update the GNIS, and assist Interior offices in Alaska, Alaska Native entities, and nonfederal organizations in “adopting names for landmarks to honor the history and culture of Alaskan people.” The [GNIS](#) lists the summit as [Mount McKinley](#).

Lake America. On August 27, 2026, President Trump signed [EO 14422](#), “[Honoring the American History of the Great Lakes and Renaming Lake Ontario as Lake America](#).” Similar to [EO 14172](#), the EO directed the Secretary to take all appropriate actions within 30 days to rename Lake Ontario as Lake America, update the GNIS, remove all references to the previous names, and provide guidance to ensure all federal references reflect the name change. Subsequently, the Secretary issued [SO 3453](#) directing BGN to implement the renaming and update the GNIS. Both the [GNIS](#) and the [GNS](#) reflect this change.

Nonfederal Adoption

Geographic place names set forth by the BGN apply only to the standardization of federal publications. Administrative decisions by the BGN and other executive actions pertaining to geographic name changes do not necessarily apply in an international context. For example, the BGN has determined that the “Sea of Japan” is the appropriate standard name for the body of water separating the Korean Peninsula and the Japanese Archipelago. However, the Republic of Korea historically has objected to the name and instead refers to this body of water as the “East Sea.” Similar disputes have arisen surrounding the renaming of the Gulf of America or Lake America. To address such discrepancies, the [United Nations Group of Experts on Geographical Names \(UNGEGN\)](#)—an international body established by the United Nations Economic and Social Council—has issued a resolution indicating that “when countries sharing a given geographical feature do not succeed in agreeing on a common name ... the name used by each of the countries concerned will be accepted” ([Resolution II/25](#)). Thus, depending on the context, one or both of the “Gulf of America” and “Gulf of Mexico”—or

“Lake America” and “Lake Ontario”—may appear on international maps.

Similarly, BGN decisions are not required to be adopted by nonfederal domestic entities, such as private company applications (e.g., Google Maps and Apple Maps); however, some nonfederal entities have chosen to do so or generally have a policy to defer to GNIS nomenclature. For example, Google’s policy is to “[reflect name changes in official government sources](#).” This means updates in the GNIS are reflected for Google Maps users in the United States, while users in Canada see “Lake Ontario,” as the Canadian naming authority has not made such a change. Whether or to what degree nonfederal publications adopt the name changes resulting from President Trump’s EOs has raised issues both [domestically](#) and [internationally](#).

Issues for Congress

In certain instances, Congress has established names for geographic features in statute or directed the BGN to change certain geographic names. For example, multiple Congresses have considered legislation related to the naming of Mount McKinley/Denali, as well as the surrounding national park. In 1980, Congress changed the name of the national park where Mount McKinley is located to Denali National Park and Preserve, from its earlier name of Mount McKinley National Park ([P.L. 96-487](#)). [EO 14172](#) specifies that the park area surrounding Mount McKinley “shall retain the name Denali National Park and Preserve.” On February 13, 2025, following the issuance of [EO 14172](#), legislation was introduced to, once again, designate the mountain as Denali ([S. 573](#)).

Congress has also considered legislation to codify certain geographic names promulgated by the BGN. For example, on May 8, 2025, the House of Representatives passed [H.R. 276](#), which, if enacted, would codify the name Gulf of America for federal use. Following the issuance of [EO 14422](#), [H.R. 10196](#) was introduced to do the same for Lake Ontario.

Previous Congresses have differed in their approaches related to adjustments of BGN authorities or directives. For example, the Reconciliation in Place Names Act ([S. 2894/H.R. 2843](#)) in the 119th Congress would direct the Secretary to establish a committee to advise the BGN on proposals for revising geographic feature names considered offensive or derogatory. Other legislation in the 119th Congress—the Hands Off Our Boca Chica Beach Act ([H.R. 9779](#))—would, among other provisions, require the DNC to notify Members when it receives proposals that would affect areas the Member represents. Congress has also previously considered proposals to prohibit or condition funding to the BGN in appropriations laws. For example, the Senate-passed Interior, Environment, and Related Agencies Appropriations Bill, 2026 ([S. 2431](#)) would have prohibited the use of funding for the promulgation of any other name than “Denali” for the currently named Mount McKinley. The provision was not included in the full-year Interior appropriations law for FY2026.

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